Terms of Reference of the ISO 639 Maintenance Agency (ISO 639/MA)

1 Background and role of the ISO 639/MA

1.1 Background

ISO 639, *Code for individual languages and language groups*, developed jointly by ISO/TC 37/SC 2 (leading committee) and ISO/TC 46/SC 4, specifies the following sets of language identifiers:

- Set 1: two-letter language identifiers (originally according to ISO 639-1:2002 based on normative documents published in 1967) for major, mostly national individual languages,
- Set 2: three-letter language identifiers (originally according to ISO 639-2:1998 based on documents widely used since the 1970s) for a larger number of widely known individual languages (including all individual languages covered by Set 1) and a number of language groups,
- Set 3: three-letter language identifiers (originally according to ISO 639-3:2007) covering all individual languages (including all individual languages covered by Set 2),
- Set 5[1]: three-letter language identifiers (originally according to ISO 639-5:2008) covering a larger set of language groups (including all language groups covered by Set 2).

In the ISO 639 language code, each individual language and each language group is represented by a language code element. Each language code element is comprised of the following components:

- Core components:
  - one unique language reference name,
  - either one, or two, or three language identifiers (from Set 1, Set 2, Set 3, Set 5),
- Additional components:
  - language names in English and French
  - supplementary information.

ISO 639 gives comprehensive provisions for the identification and assignment of language identifiers to individual languages or language groups, as well as for the creation of new language code elements or for the modification of existing ones.

A Maintenance Agency (ISO 639/MA) has been established by the ISO Technical Management Board (ISO/TMB) for the purpose of maintaining the ISO 639 language code, operating under these Terms of Reference (ToR), which have been approved by the ISO/TMB.

1.2 Role of ISO 639/MA

The primary role of the ISO 639/MA is to maintain the ISO 639 language code for the representation of individual languages and language groups. This role includes receiving, analysing, resolving, and publishing the requests for changes to the ISO 639 language code. The 639/MA works on a continuous basis through the procedures described in this document, ensuring that language code elements do

[1] For legacy reasons, the sets are numbered in line with the Parts of the former ISO 639-series, where the sets were originally defined. For that reason, there is no "Set 4".

not contradict each other, and that no language identifier represents more than one individual language or language group, based on the provisions for the selection and coding of individual languages or language groups specified in ISO 639.

The three former Registration Authorities (Infoterm, Library of Congress and SIL International, see Clause 4) in the previous organizational scheme for maintaining the ISO 639 series (1st editions, published between 1998 and 2008) hold substantial research material, background information and extensive legacy data related to the ISO 639 language code, and represent major stakeholders of the main user groups of the ISO 639 language code and its sets of language identifiers. In the current maintenance framework, they have become the three Language Coding Agencies (LCAs), which are key members of the ISO 639/MA, each taking responsibility for specific sets of language identifiers of the ISO 639 language code, as specified in Clause 4 of this document.

2 Composition of the ISO 639/MA

2.1 Voting Members

The ISO 639/MA comprises 9 to 11 Voting Members appointed as follows.

1. Three Voting Members are appointed by the three LCAs in accordance with their internal procedures:
   - one Voting Member is appointed by Infoterm, see 4.1,
   - one Voting Member is appointed by the Library of Congress (LoC), see 4.2,
   - one Voting Member is appointed by SIL International (SIL), see 4.3.

In case of unavailability of an LCA-appointed Voting Member, the LCA can appoint a replacement.

2. ISO/TC 37/SC 2 and ISO/TC 46/SC 4 appoint two Voting Members each for three-year terms, as follows:
   - Every three years, the Secretariats of the Committees shall launch a call for candidates from P-members. Candidacies shall be documented with a biography of the candidate demonstrating his/her knowledge in applied linguistics or in language coding.
   - The Secretariats of the Committees shall conduct an election of the candidates within their respective Committees.
   - To be elected, candidates shall be approved by two-thirds majority of the P-members voting.
   - Should there be more than two approved candidates from TC 37/SC 2 or from TC 46/SC 4, the two candidates having collected the highest numbers of votes in each Committee shall be retained as the appointed Voting Members. The remaining approved candidates shall constitute a pool of elected candidates who shall replace the Voting Members appointed by the Committees in case of unavailability.
   - There is no limit to the number of terms that a Voting Member appointed by the Committees can serve, provided he/she is re-elected following the above process.

- Where insufficient nominations have been received or approved, these seats shall remain vacant. At any time, a P-member can nominate a candidate to fill a vacancy for the remainder of the term, following the above process.

3. A minimum of two and not more than four Organizations that are recognized as major stakeholders of the Language Code can nominate one Voting Member each in accordance with their internal procedures, provided the following criteria are met:

    - To be eligible to nominate a Voting Member, an Organization shall be in liaison with ISO/TC 37/SC 2 and/or ISO/TC 46/SC 4 and be recognized as a major stakeholder of the ISO 639 language code.
    - Individuals nominated by eligible Organizations shall document that they are knowledgeable experts in applied linguistics or in language coding for vetting that they are qualified candidates. Candidates shall then be approved by two-thirds majority of the Voting Members appointed by both the LCAs and the Committees (points 1. and 2. above, respectively).
    - Should there be more than four eligible Organizations interested in nominating a candidate, a waiting list shall be constituted, where the Organizations shall be listed in the order in which they expressed their interest.
    - There is no limit to the number of terms that a Voting Member nominated by an eligible Organization can serve, provided he/she is re-elected following the above process.
    - Should there be fewer than four eligible Organizations interested in nominating a candidate, the number of seats shall remain vacant. At any time, an eligible Organization can nominate a candidate to fill a vacancy in line with the procedures above.

Responsibilities: The Voting Members have an obligation to actively participate in all discussions and to cast a vote in all ballots to resolve Change Requests (CR). In performing their function, they can consult further knowledgeable Experts on individual languages (or language groups) or on language coding during the Registration (see 5.1), Commenting (see 5.2) and Deliberation and voting (see 5.3) phases.

2.2 Chairperson

The Chairperson of the ISO 639/MA is a Voting Member elected for a period of three years by the Voting Members. Re-election is possible two times for a maximum period of nine years.

Responsibilities: The Chairperson oversees the ISO 639 language code maintenance operations. He/she chairs the 639/MA meetings and discussions, ensuring all voices are heard and driving the group towards resolving the cases. In the exercise of his/her function, the Chairperson is assisted by the Secretariat of the ISO 639/MA.

3 ISO 639/MA Secretariat (MAS)

The ISO 639/MA Secretariat (MAS) is assigned to SCC[2], the ISO member body for Canada. It handles the administrative tasks of the maintenance procedures (see Clause 5) through an appointed Secretary

[2] SCC holds the Secretariat of ISO/TC 37/SC 2, leading Committee for the development of ISO 639 and responsible for its maintenance, in cooperation with ISO/TC 46/SC 4.

supported by a Secretariat Support Team (SST). It delegates to the three LCAs the entire execution of the Registration phase (see 5.1), as well as the maintenance and publication of the respective databases of language code elements.

Responsibilities: the MAS (its appointed Secretary and the Secretary Support Team) is responsible for the following tasks:

- Receiving CRs from Submitters, and forwarding those to the relevant LCA for registration,
- Circulating all documents required for the 639/MA deliberation and voting,
- Scheduling 639/MA meetings and 639/MA ballots,
- Communicating the final 639/MA decisions to the Submitters, except for the Registration phase, where the task is delegated to the LCAs,
- Maintaining the list of Voting Members and relevant Experts consulted,
- Maintaining the list of eligible Organizations to nominate Voting Members,
- Sending out the ISO 639/MA Quarterly Newsletter (see 6.2, point 3.) and maintaining its mailing list,
- Producing the publicly available ISO 639/MA Annual Report (see 6.2, point 3.), and providing it to the annual meetings of ISO/TC 46/SC 4 and ISO/TC 37/SC 2, preferably by the end of March.

Secretariat Support Team (SST): The SST assists the Secretary in all administrative tasks for which the MAS has responsibility. For the purposes of coordination, the three LCAs nominate a language coding expert each (typically the respective Registrar) to the SST.

4 Language Coding Agencies (LCAs)

The MAS delegates the maintenance and publication of the databases of the ISO 639 language code elements to the three LCAs, see 4.1, 4.2 and 4.3.

Responsibilities: Each LCA is responsible for:

- maintaining the database of the set(s) of language identifiers of the ISO 639 language code for which it has been assigned responsibility,
- publishing the database of the set(s) of language identifiers of the ISO 639 language code on its public website,
- providing instructions on how to submit a Change Request (CR) on its public website,
- receiving CRs for additions, modifications or deprecations of language code elements corresponding to its set(s) of language identifiers of the ISO 639 language code (see 5.1, point 1),
- vetting the CRs among its experts against the provisions of ISO 639:2023, 5.8.2, as appropriate in cooperation with the other LCAs (see 5.1, point 3.),
- fully processing the CRs that concern the additional components of a language code element (see 1.1 and 5.1, point 4.),

- making the results of the maintenance publicly available through the Change Request Index (CR Index, see 6.2, point 2.),
- maintaining records of past modifications (including deprecations) of language code elements.

For the purposes of coordination, the LCAs nominate a language coding expert (typically the respective Registrar) to the SST.

4.1 LCA for Set 1 of the ISO 639 language code: International Information Centre for Terminology (Infoterm)

Infoterm functions as the LCA for Set 1 of the ISO 639 language code.

Infoterm is responsible for receiving and registering CRs that are unique to language identifiers in Set 1. It cooperates and coordinates activities with the Library of Congress (LoC), which is hosting the language code elements with two-letter language identifiers of Set 1 alongside the language code elements with three-letter language identifiers of Set 2.

The data for Set 1 are publicly available at: http://www.loc.gov/standards/iso639-2/

CRs and other questions concerning Set 1 can be addressed to:

International Information Centre for Terminology (Infoterm)
Kirchengasse 44/1, c/o CO-SPACE, 1070 Vienna, AUSTRIA
Website: www.infoterm.info

4.2 LCA for Set 2 and Set 5 of the ISO 639 language code: Library of Congress (LoC)

LoC functions as the LCA for Set 2 and Set 5 of the ISO 639 language code.

LoC is responsible for receiving and registering CRs that are unique to language identifiers in Set 2 and Set 5.

The data for Set 2 are publicly available at: http://www.loc.gov/standards/iso639-2/

The data for Set 5 are publicly available at: http://www.loc.gov/standards/iso639-5/

CRs and other questions concerning Set 2 and Set 5 can be addressed to:

Library of Congress (LoC)
101 Independence Ave, SE
Washington, DC 20540
Website for Information Resource Retrieval Standards: www.loc.gov/librarians/standards

4.3 LCA for Set 3 of the ISO 639 language code: SIL International (SIL)

SIL functions as the LCA for Set 3 of the ISO 639 language code.

SIL is responsible for receiving and registering CRs that are unique to language identifiers in Set 3 for the comprehensive coverage of languages, excluding those in Set 2 for which LoC is responsible. SIL is also responsible for maintaining the mapping from macrolanguages to their encompassed individual languages.

The data for Set 3 are publicly available at: https://iso639-3.sil.org

CRs and other questions concerning Set 3 can be addressed to:

SIL International
Attn.: ISO 639-3 Registrar
7500 W. Camp Wisdom Rd.
Dallas, Texas 75236-5629 USA
Website: http://www.sil.org

5 Procedure for the maintenance of the ISO 639 language code

Overview: In order to request a new language code element or a modification to an existing language code element, in whole or in part, it is necessary to submit a Change Request (CR) to the ISO 639 Maintenance Agency (ISO 639/MA). For this purpose, Submitters shall use the Change Request Form (CR Form, accessible at https://standards.iso.org/iso/639/ed-2/en/). The ISO 639/MA then processes the CRs following a procedure that comprises four phases. Details on the four phases are given in 5.1 to 5.4. A flowchart is presented in the Annex. Each CR is given a reference number and is registered in the CR Database (see 6.1, point 2.) to track its progress.

5.1 Registration phase

Objective: Receive a Submitter's CR for the ISO 639 language code (using the CR Form), and prepare it for public comment (see 5.2) if it falls within the scope of what is acceptable by the provisions of ISO 639.

Oversight: LCA responsible for the affected set of language identifiers, who consults the other LCAs as needed.

Input: A CR is received by the MAS or by one of the LCAs

1. Submitters are encouraged to submit their CR to the relevant LCA. Where the Submitter is unclear about the relevant LCA, the CR can be submitted to the MAS, who shall forward it to the appropriate LCA.

2. The LCA with responsibility for the concerned set of language identifiers enters the request into the CR Database.

3. The LCA with responsibility for the concerned set of language identifiers uses an LCA-internal review process to determine whether the Submitter's request meets the provisions of ISO 639:2023, 5.8.2, to be further processed. If necessary, the Submitter is asked for further information or clarifications until the LCA deems the request ready for consideration by the ISO 639/MA.

    a) If the CR falls outside the scope of what is acceptable by the provisions of ISO 639:2023, 5.8.2, the LCA informs the MA that the case should be rejected.

        i. If any Voting Member objects to the rejection, the CR is accepted and posted as "Pending" on the public CR Index, and proceeds to the Commenting phase (see 5.2). The LCA informs the Submitter with copy to the MAS.

ii. In the absence of an objection from any Voting Member after a period of 2 weeks, the CR is rejected. The LCA informs the Submitter with copy to the MAS.

- If the Submitter opposes the rejection, the Submitter is given an opportunity to supplement the arguments given in the CR, at which point the CR is accepted and posted as "Pending" on the public CR Index, and proceeds to the Commenting phase (see 5.2).

- In the absence of opposition from the Submitter, the CR is rejected. A new CR may be submitted if it meets the criteria specified in the rejection communication. The CR remains private with respect to the records of the ISO 639/MA and does not become part of the public record on the LCA's website.

b) Well-elaborated CRs within the scope of what is acceptable by the provisions of ISO 639:2023, 5.8.2, are accepted and posted on the public CR Index with the status "Pending", and proceed to the Commenting phase (see 5.2).

4. Accepted CRs that concern the additional components of a language code element (names of the language in English or French, and supplementary information, see 1.1) may be directly resolved by the responsible LCA, if necessary in consultation with the other LCAs. The LCA informs the MA about the intended modification and, in the absence of an objection from any Voting Member within 2 weeks, implements the requested change (see 5.4), and the case is resolved. In case of an objection from any Voting Member, the CR is posted as "Pending" on the public CR Index, and proceeds to the Commenting phase (see 5.2).

Output: The CR is either rejected as out of scope, or advanced to the Implementation phase (see 5.4) if it concerns the additional components of a language code element, or registered as "pending" on the public CR Index and passed on to the Commenting phase (see 5.2).

5.2 Commenting phase

Objective: Gather comments from the Voting Members and consulted Experts, as well as from the public, and collate them for discussion in the Deliberation and voting phase (see 5.3).

Oversight: LCA responsible for the affected set of language identifiers.

Input: An issue of the official ISO 639 Quarterly Newsletter announces the new CR and makes a public call for comments.

1. The public commenting period remains open for 90 days. Anyone who reads the CR may submit comments that explain their agreement with, or opposition to, the proposed CR. Such comments will become part of the public record of the CR Index.

2. During the commenting period, Voting Members and consulted Experts in specific individual languages (or language groups) or in language coding shall read the CR. The Voting Members may submit comments that will be shared within the ISO 639/MA, but not with the public. They need not comment when they see no problems but shall submit a written comment to discuss any problems with the CR that they observe.

3. Voting Members and consulted Experts should forward the CR to other relevant Experts in their professional network and solicit their comments, which are typically included as part of the public record.

4. At the end of the commenting period, the LCA reviews all of the comments and prepares the CR for the Deliberation and voting phase (see 5.3). In doing so, the LCA may revise the text of the original CR (including additional information from the Submitter) and appends all of the public comments. To expedite processing in the next phase, the LCA also provides a summary to indicate whether there is consensus or a division of opinion.

Output: The CR is ready for deliberation and voting by the Voting Members (see 5.3).

5.3 Deliberation and voting phase

Objective: Deliberation within the ISO 639/MA upon the result of a MAS call for comments, followed by formal voting to decide on the rejection or approval of the CR.

Oversight: Chairperson.

Input: The MAS receives the CR (with its compiled comments) from the LCA that has been processing the CR.

1. The MAS invites the Voting Members and consulted Experts to review the proposed CR and provide written comments with a deadline of 20 days, extended to 40 days at the request of any Voting Member. When additional expert knowledge is needed, the Voting Members and consulted Experts are expected to solicit comments from additional knowledgeable Experts.

2. The MAS collects the comments for the Chairperson's assessment:

    a. If the comments reflect broad consensus, the MAS calls for a formal vote from the Voting Members.

    b. If the comments reflect a division of opinions, the MAS calls for a discussion among the Voting Members and consulted Experts. As the outcome, the Voting Members either decide that they are ready to vote, or they request modifications to the CR and call for a second round of comments that shall be concluded by a formal vote from the Voting Members to resolve the CR.

3. Once the Voting Members have cast their votes, there are two possible outcomes:

    a. Acceptance of the CR, which requires approval by a two-thirds majority of the Voting Members. The resulting change is implemented by the LCAs (see 5.4).

    b. Rejection of the CR, when it fails to be accepted by a two-thirds majority of the Voting Members. The case is resolved. The status of the CR changes from “pending” to “rejected”. The MAS notifies the Submitter accordingly. A formal statement explaining the grounds for rejection is issued by the ISO 639/MA and posted as part of the public record. A new CR may be submitted if it meets the criteria specified in the rejection notice.

Output: A formal CR vote has been carried out, resulting in its acceptance or rejection.

5.4 Implementation phase

Objective: Update the ISO 639 language code when the CR is approved.

Oversight: ISO 639/MAS and LCAs.

Input: CRs accepted in the Registration phase (i.e. concerning the additional components of a

language code element, see 5.1), or CRs that have been accepted in formal voting (see 5.3).

1. The accepted modification(s) in a language code element are implemented by the LCAs.
2. The MAS notifies the Submitter accordingly.
3. The status of the CR changes from “pending” to “adopted”

Output: The CR is resolved.

6 639/MA working environment and publication of information

6.1 Working environment, restricted to the ISO 639/MA

1. The ISO 639/MA shall use the following applications of the ISO platform for its internal operation:
   - ISO Documents (for sharing documents),
   - ISO Ballots (for voting),
   - ISO Meetings (for meeting registration).
2. The ISO 639 MA shall use the LCAs platforms to record internal information on the status of past and current CRs. This step includes:
   - The Change Request Database (CR Database), an ISO 639/MA-internal database for documenting all maintenance activities and results. It is hosted by SIL.
   - Correspondence generated at the phases in Clause 5, which is considered non-public and is archived by the LCAs.

6.2 Publication of information

1. The ISO Maintenance Portal, https://standards.iso.org/iso/639/ed-2/en/, allows public access to the following:
   - The ISO 639/MA-ToR (this document),
   - The Change Request Form.

The ISO Maintenance Portal also directs the users to the Websites of the LCAs and to the Website of the MAS to access the ISO 639 language code and the additional related publicly accessible material.

2. The LCA Websites provide the following public information and communication:
   - The updated tables of the ISO 639 language code,
   - The Change Request Form,
   - The Change Request Index (CR Index), a public website showing the content of all pending CRs and the outcomes of all past CRs. It is hosted by SIL.

   The LCAs can use additional channels to disseminate the public information.

3. The MAS Website provides the following public information and communication:

- The official ISO 639 Quarterly Newsletter, disseminated at the end of each quarter. The newsletter provides the most recent status information from the CR Index. This includes a list with information on the status of ongoing CRs, including:
    - newly implemented CRs, with references to further detailed information,
    - newly registered CRs, with requests for comments by a given deadline,
    - other pending CRs that are under consideration by the ISO 639/MA.
- The ISO 639/MA Annual Report, summarizing the information contained in the last four ISO 639 Quarterly Newsletters, supplemented by information from the LCAs.

ANNEX – Flowchart for the procedure for the maintenance of the ISO 639 language code.